



GUWAHATI

Out In the Cold

Strange are the ways of ULFA commander-in-chief Paresh Baruah. The head of the military wing of the United Liberation Front of Asom seems to have resorted to Gandhigiri in a last-ditch attempt at fulfilling his dream of an independent Assam. Baruah has just asked the Government to hold a plebiscite in the state to ascertain if all native Assamese really want a separate country. His request is aimed at replicating Mahatma Gandhi who would ascertain public opinion before starting a movement against the British. Baruah is believed to be hiding in China's Yunnan province bordering Myanmar and his statements are seen as the outfit's ploy to keep public sympathy alive. Baruah has recently also apologised for ULFA's "barbaric act". He was referring to an Independence Day blast carried out five years ago in Dhemaji, Upper Assam, which killed 15 children. Following the arrest of ULFA Chairman Arabinda Rajkhowa, Baruah is sending daily e-mails to local media houses to assert his presence and keep the organisation united. Until now, ULFA has refused to come forward for talks if the issue of sovereignty is not included in the dialogue. However, it has not yet released a map of a sovereign Assam. With Myanmar agreeing to share intelligence with Delhi, the Government must believe Baruah and his comrades will soon be reunited—behind bars.

RAJKHOWA
BEING
PRODUCED IN
A GUWAHATI
COURT

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persons
formed ULFA
at the Rang
Ghar in
Sibsagar on
April 7, 1979.
Their mission
was to create
a "sovereign"
Assam
through
an armed
struggle.

by Kaushik Deka